THE BRAND OPERATING SYSTEM TOOLKIT

Five Frameworks from Think Like a Brand, Not a Bank

HOW TO USE THIS TOOLKIT

These five templates come from Think Like a Brand, Not a Bank (Second Edition). These are operating tools designed to turn brand conviction into daily practice.

Start here:

- If you're unclear on who owns brand execution → F/M/B Mapping
- If customers can't quickly explain what you do → Box→Edge Positioning
- If you're leading with features instead of outcomes → Pain→Promise→Proof
- If you suspect your strategy is built on outdated beliefs → Assumption Audit
- If projects keep drifting off-message → Creative Brief

How to get the most from these:

- Do them with your team. Misalignment surfaces faster in groups.
- Write rough first drafts. Perfection kills momentum.
- Test outputs with real customers or prospects. Internal consensus isn't validation.
- Revisit quarterly. Markets shift. Assumptions expire.

A note on order:

These templates work independently, but they build on each other. If you're starting from scratch:

1. Assumption Audit (surface what you think you know)
2. Box→Edge Positioning (establish clarity before differentiation)
3. Pain→Promise→Proof (build your narrative system)
4. F/M/B Mapping (clarify who owns execution)
5. Creative Brief (set standards for every project)

Want help implementing?

BrandThnk helps fintechs and financial institutions implement brand-first thinking. Learn more at BrandThnk.co.

TEMPLATE 1: F/M/B MAPPING

Clarify who owns brand execution across your organization

Why this matters

Most financial institutions struggle with brand execution because ownership is unclear. Marketing owns messaging. Product owns features. Operations owns delivery. But who owns making sure they all align?

Usually, no one.

The F/M/B Model creates clear ownership for brand execution without rigid silos. Think of it as the operating system that runs your brand operating system.

STEP 1: Map your layers

List the specific roles that sit in each layer of your organization.

FRONTLINE: The Customer Interaction Layer

These are the people who directly engage with customers across all touchpoints. Their brand role: Deliver the promise.

Examples: Branch bankers, tellers, relationship managers, contact center reps, customer success teams

Who sits in your Frontline?

MIDLINE: The Experience Orchestration Layer

These are the people who design journeys, communications, and ensure continuity across touchpoints. Their brand role: Connect the dots.

Examples: Marketing, UX, Product Marketing, Growth teams, Data & Analytics, CRM specialists

Who sits in your Midline?

BACKLINE: The Enablement Layer

These are the people who build and maintain the platforms, processes, and systems. Their brand role: Make it possible.

Examples: Operations, Engineering, Product, IT, Risk, Compliance, Infrastructure teams

Who sits in your Backline?

STEP 2: Diagnose information flow

Answer these questions honestly. Gaps here are where brand execution breaks down.

When Frontline identifies customer friction, how does that information reach Backline?

When Backline builds new capabilities, how does Frontline learn to use them effectively?

Who is responsible for ensuring what marketing promises matches what operations delivers?

Where do handoffs between layers create customer experience gaps?

STEP 3: Identify your priority gaps

Based on your answers above, list the top three gaps in your F/M/B alignment.

#	Gap	Which layers are disconnected?	Owner to fix
1.			
2.			
3.			

KEY PRINCIPLE

Brand isn't marketing's job. It's everyone's job. But everyone's job doesn't mean no one's job.

Frontline delivers the promise in every interaction. Midline designs journeys that work across touchpoints. Backline builds systems that enable the brand experience.

When each layer owns their part and collaborates at the intersections, brand thinking becomes operational reality.

TEMPLATE 2: BOX→EDGE POSITIONING

Establish category clarity before differentiation

Why this matters

Most marketing advice says: Differentiate! Stand out! Be unique!

When you lead with your edge before establishing your box, you force prospects to work harder to understand what you are. Brains can't evaluate differentiation until they've categorized you.

Box first. Edge second.

STEP 1: Define your box

Your box is your category. It gives prospects an easy mental file. It answers: "What are you?"

Write your box in one sentence, using plain language a stranger would understand:

The 5-second test: Read your box statement to someone unfamiliar with your company. Can they categorize you in 5 seconds or less? - Yes → Move to Step 2 - No → Simplify until they can

STEP 2: Map competitor boxes

What categories do your top competitors claim?

Competitor	Their box (category claim)
1.	
2.	
3.	

Are you claiming the same box as competitors? Box establishes credibility. Edge creates differentiation.

STEP 3: Define your edge

Your edge is your differentiation within the established category. It answers: "Why are you different?"

Write your edge in one sentence:

The 10-second test: After someone understands your box, can they articulate your difference in 10 seconds?

STEP 4: Combine and validate

Write your combined positioning statement: "We're a [BOX] that [EDGE]."

Validation questions: - Could three different companies claim this? If yes → too vague. - Would competitors need to change operations to copy this? If yes → defensible. - Does this require infrastructure changes? If yes → genuinely differentiating.

KEY PRINCIPLE

If your positioning could describe three different types of companies, you don't have positioning. You have adjectives.

Box gives you credibility. Edge gives you differentiation. You need both, in that order.

TEMPLATE 3: PAIN→PROMISE→PROOF

Build narrative that matches how brains make decisions

Why this matters

Most financial institutions lead with proof. They list features and hope customers figure out why they matter.

Neuroscience shows rational decisions require emotional processing first. People feel before they think.

Start with pain. Follow with your promise. Then provide proof.

STEP 1: Identify the pain

Pain is the emotional trigger that makes someone start looking for solutions.

What situation isn't working for your customer?

What frustration, confusion, or limitation do they feel?

Write your pain statement:

Pain that works: "Gig workers don't fit existing banking categories. They're stuck between personal and business."

Pain that doesn't work: "People want better banking."

STEP 2: Define your promise

Promise is your commitment to an outcome. It's what customers will be able to do or become.

What outcome do you commit to?

Write your promise statement:

Promise that works: "We'll guide you through early military financial complexity."

Promise that doesn't work: "We provide comprehensive banking solutions."

STEP 3: Identify your proof

Proof is evidence you can deliver. Now features matter—as evidence, standalone benefits.

Feature or capability	How it proves the promise
1.	
2.	
3.	

Feature or capability	How it proves the promise
4.	

STEP 4: Assemble your narrative

Pain:

Promise:

Proof:

STEP 5: Test flexibility

A strong narrative works at multiple altitudes. Test yours:

Company level (how you describe the organization):

Product level (how you position a specific offering):

Sales conversation (how a rep explains your value):

KEY PRINCIPLE

Your products are essential. But they're proof of your promise, the promise itself.

The promise is what you enable customers to do or become. The proof demonstrates you can deliver.

TEMPLATE 4: ASSUMPTION AUDIT

Surface beliefs that may be limiting growth

Why this matters

Your biggest competitor isn't another fintech or bank. It's the belief that you already understand your market.

Success breeds certainty. Certainty breeds assumptions. And assumptions quietly erode the curiosity that drives growth.

Sometimes the biggest act of brand courage is admitting what you no longer know.

STEP 1: Surface your assumptions

List your organization's core beliefs. Be honest. Include the things "everyone knows" even if no one has verified them recently.

About your customers:

What do you believe about who they are?

What do you believe about what they value?

What do you believe about how they make decisions?

About your market:

What do you believe about market size or growth?

What do you believe about what the market wants?

About your competitors:

What do you believe about their strengths?

What do you believe they can't or won't do?

About your own capabilities:

What do you believe you're known for?

What do you believe you do better than competitors?

STEP 2: Assess evidence quality

For each assumption, rate the evidence quality honestly.

Assumption	Evidence quality	Last validated	Source
	☐ Strong ☐ Weak ☐ None		
	☐ Strong ☐ Weak ☐ None		
	☐ Strong ☐ Weak ☐ None		
	☐ Strong ☐ Weak ☐ None		

Strong = Validated within 6 months. **Weak** = Old data or anecdotes. **None** = "Everyone just knows this."

STEP 3: Prioritize what to test

Top 3 assumptions to validate before your next strategic decision:

Assumption 1:

How we'll test it:

Assumption 2:

How we'll test it:

Assumption 3:

How we'll test it:

KEY PRINCIPLE

The question isn't "How well do we know our customers?"

The question is "What are we assuming about our customers that might be wrong?"

TEMPLATE 5: CREATIVE BRIEF

Set the standard before work begins

Why this matters

This is your salt shaker.

In Danny Meyer's restaurants, managers are trained to notice when the salt shaker moves off-center and calmly move it back. Dramatic. Punitive. Just consistent correction to the standard.

The creative brief is your brand's salt shaker. It sets the standard before work begins. When projects drift, you coach back to the brief.

PROJECT INFORMATION

Project name:
Date:
Owner:
Deadline:

1. OBJECTIVE

What is this project trying to accomplish? Be specific.

How will we measure success?

2. AUDIENCE

Who specifically are we trying to reach?

What pain are they experiencing?

What aspiration are they working toward?

3. KEY MESSAGE

If the audience remembers one thing from this project, what should it be?

Write it in one sentence:

Does this connect to your brand promise? How?

4. PROOF POINTS

What evidence supports the key message? List 2-4 proof points:

1.
2.
3.
4.

5. TONE AND CONSTRAINTS

How should this project feel?

What must we avoid?

Compliance or regulatory requirements?

6. DELIVERABLES AND TIMELINE

Deliverable	Owner	Due date

7. STAKEHOLDER SIGN-OFF

Name	Role	Approved	Date
		☐	
		☐	
		☐	

KEY PRINCIPLE

The job isn't preventing drift. The job is consistent, gentle correction back to the standard.

People will move the salt shaker. That's failure. That's Tuesday. Your discipline is moving it back.

WHAT'S NEXT?

You now have the frameworks. The question is: will you use them?

Pick one template. Complete it this week. Just completely.

Then pick another.

Build the muscle through practice.

If you want help implementing

BrandThnk works with fintechs and financial institutions ready to implement brand-first thinking. We help you move from frameworks to execution.

Visit BrandThnk.co to start the conversation.

These frameworks are from **Think Like a Brand, Not a Bank** *(Second Edition) by Allison Netzer*

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